one of their community was involved in a case. But there were also Armenians, Portuguese, Ethiopians, Jews, Christians, Parsees, Sikhs, Buddhists, and more. Even among the Muslims there were people of many ethnicities and origins. There were Arabs and Persians settled in the coastal areas, there were traders in every seaport and there were also the Turks, Uzbeks, Afghans, and Indian shaikhzadas. Other differences existed between the Shias of the Deccan and the Sunnis of the North, and then again there was a great movement of each into the other's area. In due course, the Padshah would find novel ways, and use unique symbols and formulations, to weld all these diverse people and religions into a single empire.

Shamsuddin Ataka Khan at this point held the highest posts— wakil and diwan (finance minister). But, ultimately, according to the Timurid model of sovereignty, all power resided in the emperor himself. All important assignments remained the prerogative of the emperor and Akbar would spend a great deal of time and energy learning to judge the true nature and potential of his men. He would be unswayed by glorious pedigrees and unmoved by lowly origins. His great skill, honed over years of careful observation of those around him, would be to spot the unique talent of each man he encountered and enable the greatest expression of that talent. For that he would go far beyond the narrow limitations of sharia law and the charmed circle of Turani noblemen. And fate, too, would play her capricious part.

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